Khurasan. The Shansabanis had come a long way from their obscure and humble beginnings among the nomads and transhumant groups of Ghur; they were now imperial contenders, on the brink of establishing a trans-regional empire.

Arguably, among the most pivotal moments in the Shansabanis' imperial arc was the conquest of Ghazna in AH 569/1173–1174 CE. But rather than a centrally directed expansion of territorial presence, this conquest brought about the establishment of a third Shansabani branch at the once magnificent Yamini imperial capital. With the crowning of Shihab al-Din as Sultan Mu'izz al-Din of Ghazna, the Shansabani empire took on a confederate yet centrifugal identity of hierarchically allied agnatic lineages, which were always vying for greater independence. Indeed, the Ghazna Shansabanis likely had the greatest momentum toward this independence, given their access to new territorial conquests and economic resources to the east in India. In any case, Chapter 5 explored the Shansabanis' initial architectural traces at Ghazna, which evinced a shift toward residence in the previous rulers' palaces: these were grandly renovated befitting the new imperial occupants. Quite plausibly, the Ghazna Shansabanis' incorporation of palace residency – alongside tent-dwelling – was both an emulation of their defeated and displaced predecessors, and also a response to politico-economic mores, this time pertaining in the region of Zabulistan and incumbent on this new lineage if they were to exercise effective imperial control. Overall, the mode of building empire that the Ghazna Shansabanis evinced throughout Zabulistan and Zamindawar could be termed *re-inscription*, wherein architectural complexes and their surrounding areas were adopted under the aegis of a new rulership.

Following the eastward geo-political connections of Ghazna and Zabulistan – forming a momentum impelling the Ghaznavids all the way to the north Indian *duab* during the eleventh century – the Shansabanis also looked toward the Indus and beyond for viable imperial expansion. Chapter 6 examined the Shansabanis' forays into the Indus-dependent regions during the later 1170s and 1180s CE, which confronted them with pre-existing imperial infrastructures established by the Ghaznavids in the previous century. Re-inscription, their mode of imposing and exercising imperial control amply evidenced in their initial conquests of the Ghaznavids' core territories throughout Zabul–Zamindawar (Chapter 5), was applied on exponentially larger scales: in the case of the Indus cities and their contiguous cultural and economic landscapes, overlaying or re-inscribing the Ghaznavids' already existing imperial frameworks – for example, endowed religious/"civic" institutions, coinage, circuits of mobility – with patronage proclaiming Shansabani ascendancy was the most effective in capitalizing on what was already there. Thus, the Ghazna Shansabanis were poised to attempt an imperial formation not seen in the region for a thousand years: the Ghaznavids could claim a largely peripatetic relationship with the north